

Weeding Out

If you look at blogs, for instance, you will find that most of them do not actually appeal to you, or to most others for that matter. It's actually hard to hear a nightingale over the cacophony of the Web, but thankfully, society seems to have taken care of all the "bad content" as well. The best part about the Web is that it is decentralised and anonymous (to a certain extent). This means that a 40-kilo weakling can visit a professional wrestler's blog and call him a moron openly—if that's what he feels like saying. What would be considered anti-social in our world of laws, is actually the only policing force online, and it's helping weed out the bad content and keeping the good.

Much like Wikipedia, where a few vandals are soon overcome by a lot of well wishers, we too play our part in policing the Web. Let's face it, unless you're the one who's created the content, you're not going to subject yourself to bad content. Even if you're not brutally honest, and don't leave scathing comments, others probably will, but you will do your part by forgetting about the content in question. If the majority agree with you, and forget about the content as well, pretty soon Google (if it listed the content to begin with) will forget about it, and it will be doomed to a dark alley of the Web forever. So basically, even just by surfing you're rating content, and as a result, making the Web a more enjoyable place for others!

Prosumers

We're talking about the Professional Consumer. The idea is simple, if you don't like something, instead of bitching about it, improve it. Let's take the example of *Second Life (SL)*, where you live your life in a virtual world. You're free to buy things and pay real money, and also work and make some money. Hundreds and thousands of developers logged in to *SL* and started creating models, houses and more.

Even the Open Source movement is based on Prosumers, where developers who were not happy with the software that was available, just started making their own, or modifying existing OSS to add in features and suit their needs.

Microsoft offers the XNA Framework to aid gamers who might want to try their hand at game development for the Xbox 360 or Windows platform. Instead of making developers write boring base code from scratch for every game, developers can now use the provided libraries and save a lot of time and effort. It also makes the game development process a lot easier, as is the process of porting games between XNA-based platforms—Windows and Xbox. Microsoft does not stop there either, and even offers to sell any game that you develop on its Live platform—which means that you now have potential to earn money off any game you develop.

It's not like Microsoft is doing this out of the goodness of their hearts, because what this means is that most of the gaming community is coding for Microsoft platforms, which is a big blow to its competitors. It is still a win-win situation for both us and Microsoft, and they deserve credit for such an innovation. In the near future, we should see more such projects that leverage the skills of consumers to benefit both companies and consumers. Truly, the age of the prosumer!

Crowd-sourcing

Actually, when you think about it, the entire Web is nothing but one big crowd-sourcing initiative. You, and a billion others, spend money to buy bandwidth and a PC and get online, and companies make money off you. From the subtle Google ads you see almost everywhere, to big flashy banner ads that you try and ignore, to signing up for Gmail and visiting your favourite news site, *everything* you do online is making money for some company, somewhere in the world. You are an integral part of the Web economy.

However, even if you never realised that before, we're not interested in the obvious. What's brilliant is the way in which a lot of companies use the masses to complete tasks and improve services. Google, for example, has an image tagging program that uses its audience to tag images better, which in turn makes its searches more relevant. Sure, it means that as a person who uses Google to search, you get better results, but it also means that Google is cementing its 'numero uno' slot thanks to you. Wikipedia is another example of crowdsourcing, as is YouTube, and most popular online businesses. Even offline businesses, such as Tesla Motors (www.teslamotors.com) are turning to crowdsourcing to develop a better electric car, by maintaining a rather honest and open blog.

Of course, we don't mean to sound used or abused here, because no one is forcing anyone to do anything, and all successful crowdsourcing is completely optional—Wikipedia is a prime example here again. However, it is significant that companies are using your spare time and brain power, much like the BOINC and folding@home projects, use your idle CPU power, to complete tasks that result in better products and services for you to use.

Crowdsourcing is the culmination of social networking, prosumer-grade users and a passion to contribute, and it's a trend that's here to stay. It's another feather in your cap, and another reason why you are the most important wonder of the technology-laden decades to come. Each one of you reading this article need to pat yourselves on the back, because thousands of companies across the globe (us included) are thanking you for using, making and changing technology in a way that benefits all of mankind. ■

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